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Work, play and learning in a Kpelle town

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Joking is another type of speech event, and the purpose is to make the position of the "unconvinced party" or "holdout" look ridiculous. Several examples occur in this trial. When the second older calls for drinks he is signaling that Gbokpele is wasting their time and that, by his obstinance, he has turned a serious trial into a farce. Very early in the proceedings Gbokpele is admonished for wearing his hat; this is a mock serious accusation, again designed to make him appear foolish. While joking and teasing must be well-timed to be effective they occur in any trial no matter how serious and when they occur they seem to provide welcome relief to all the participants and enjoyment for the spectators. Occasionally  83 when I was tied up with another piece of work I would send one of my school boy assistants to "cover" a trial to report back to me later. They inevitably began their report by recounting all the funny things that occurred often doubling up with laughter in the process.

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